

later. In 1852, Dickens used it in *Bleak House*: “the malady of boredom.” Author Tom Hodgkinson would agree with Dickens. In his *The Freedom Manifesto*, he has a whole chapter devoted to boredom. He writes, “If contemporary science were more sophisticated and subtle, then I’m absolutely certain that it would rank boredom as one of the central killers in the modern world. ... It would not surprise me one jot if boredom were one day revealed to be a carcinogenic.”

Read in the proper, light-hearted spirit, Hodgkinson’s book is terrific. He talks about all the ways in which modern life creates boredom — especially in the workplace.

There are many mechanical, boring jobs that “require just enough concentration to prevent you from going off into a dream but not enough really to occupy your mind.” As a result, we have boredom on a mass scale. People are bored. And they do all kinds of things to alleviate the boredom. They act like idiots. They dress like fools. Anything to kill the boredom. They may even commit acts of sabotage.

In the financial markets, people often wind up sabotaging their own portfolios out of sheer boredom. Why else put money into tiny 70-cent-share mining companies that have virtually no chance of being anything at all? Why bother chasing hyped-up biotech companies that trade at absurd levels based on flimsy prospects?

Because people are bored!

It seems exciting to lose your money in this way. It’s no different from going to a casino. (And just like a casino, these bets pay off often enough to keep people coming back.) People crave the action.

Why do people buy and sell stocks so frequently? Why can’t they just buy a stock and hold it for at least a couple of years? (Most don’t.) Why can’t people follow the more time-tested ways to wealth? I’m sure you can guess my answer by now.

People often do dumb things with their portfolio just because they’re bored. They feel they have to do something. (Here I recall that bit of wisdom from Pascal that “all men’s miseries derive from not being able to sit in a quiet room alone.”)

I know I get bored, but in a different way. For example, it’s incredible to me that people spend so much time talking about the Federal Reserve.

My newsletter peers, people in the media — they all do it. It’s